

Intel 975X Express and nForce4 SLI (Performance)

Foxconn 975X7AB-8EKR52H

Specifications

Support for LGA 775 CPU up to Core 2 Duo; 8-channel HD audio; maximum 8 GB DDR2 RAM; CrossFire support, five SATA ports; e-SATA support; SATA RAID support; Dual Gigabit LAN; up to eight USB 2.0 ports

Our Verdict

Unlike some 975X boards, this board supports a maximum DDR2 frequency of 800 MHz. The area around the CPU socket is not cluttered, permitting easy installation of a larger

heatsink. The two PCIe slots are CrossFire compatible, and apart from the normal SATA connectors, there is an e-SATA connector at the back. Dual Gigabit LAN makes this board ideal for gamers. For the overclocking fraternity, there is a dedicated entry in the BIOS—Fox Central Control Unit—that lets you do your thing. The cool combination of features, performance and price make this board a Zero1 Award winner.

Runner-Up: Intel D 975XBX



AMD MOTHERBOARDS

Socket 939 Motherboards

ASUS A8R MVP

Specifications

ATI Xpress 1600 chipset based; 2000 MHz HT bus (FSB); CrossFire ready; four DIMMs support 4 GB of DDR 400 MHz RAM; 6-channel HD compliant audio

Our Verdict

Although not future-proof, let's face it... Socket 939 motherboards are still hot due to their reduced prices and the fact that AMD 939 dual-core processors are dirt-cheap! The ASUS A8R MVP is the best board around for 939

processors, single or dual core. Good layout, great feature set, and sterling performance and stability, coupled with the fact that you get a multi-GPU-ready platform make the A8R MVP a good buy if you're on a budget, and still want good performance from your Desktop. Though the newer platforms have overshadowed Socket 939, if you need the best motherboard from that AMD 64 processor, you can't goof up here.

Runner-Up: ASUS A8R 32 MVP Deluxe



AM2 Motherboards

ASUS Crosshair

Specifications

nForce 590SLI chipset based; 2000 MHz HT Bus (FSB); SLI-ready; four DIMMs support 8 GB of DDR2 800 MHz RAM; 8-channel HD compliant audio

Our Verdict

ASUS designed the Crosshair from the PCB layer up to be a hardcore enthusiast solution. This is the best looking board we've laid our hands on for the AM2 platform. It also wins on the layout front, with the attractive heatpipe cooling solution adding visual appeal. Lacking

any sort of onboard cooling fans, the Crosshair is able to provide a quiet computing experience without compromising on stability. An eight-phase power design and lots of over-volting options in the BIOS will keep most enthusiasts happy, while SLI support will keep gamers interested as well.

Performance is excellence itself. The Crosshair is also an outstanding combination of looks, features, and a rich bundle. It's pricey, but so are Ferraris!

Runner-Up: MSI K9N SLI Platinum

